Committee: United Nations Human Rights Council

Topic: Protecting Children in Armed Conflict Zones

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1. Introduction

Children are among the most vulnerable people affected by armed conflict. Unlike adults, children often have little control over where they live, whether they can leave a conflict zone, or whether they have access to food, healthcare, and education. When conflict begins, the effects on children can extend far beyond the immediate danger of fighting. Children may be killed or injured, separated from their families, forced to leave their homes, recruited by armed groups, subjected to sexual violence, or prevented from attending school.

The United Nations has developed a number of international frameworks to protect children during armed conflict. These include the Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC), its Optional Protocol on the involvement of children in armed conflict, international humanitarian law, and the UN Security Council's Children and Armed Conflict agenda. These rules explain that children need special protection and that parties to a conflict must respect their rights.

However, the existence of these protections does not mean that they are always followed. In 2025, the United Nations verified 38,558 grave violations against children, affecting 24,174 children. These violations included killing and injuring children, recruiting children, sexual violence, abduction, attacks on schools and hospitals, and blocking humanitarian access. The UN warns that verified figures do not show every violation, because investigators may not be able to reach every area affected by conflict.

The issue is therefore not only how to create stronger protections, but also to make sure they are followed and that children receive help. The Human Rights Council can discuss these problems, raise awareness, encourage countries to improve their actions, and support international cooperation. Delegates should consider how to prevent harm, hold responsible parties accountable, and help children recover after experiencing conflict.

2. Definition of Essential Terms

a) Armed Conflict

Armed conflict is fighting between countries, between a government and an organized armed group, or between organised armed groups. The rules that apply can depend on the type of conflict, but children must be protected under International Law.

b) Child Soldier / Child Associated with Armed Forces or Armed Groups

This term refers to anyone under 18 who is recruited or used by an armed force or armed group in any role. This does not only mean children who fight. Children may be used as messengers, cooks, guards, porters, or spies, and may also face sexual violence. UNICEF reported that more than 105,000 children were verified as recruited or used between 2005 and 2022. The actual number is believed to be higher (UNICEF, 2021).

c) Grave Violations Against Children

The United Nations monitors **s**ix grave violation**s** against children in armed conflict:

1. **Killing and maiming**: killing children or causing them serious injuries.
2. **Recruitment and use:** recruiting or using children in armed forces or armed groups.
3. **Sexual violence:** rape and other forms of sexual violence against children.
4. **Attacks on schools and hospitals:** attacks against these important civilian places.
5. **Abduction:** taking children away by force.
6. **Denial of humanitarian access**: blocking or preventing essential help from reaching children.

These six violations guide the UN's monitoring and reporting work on children and armed conflict.

d) Internally Displaced Person (IDP)

An internally displaced person is someone who has been forced to leave their home because of conflict, violence, persecution, or disaster but has not crossed an international border. Displaced children may lose access to school, healthcare, food, clean water, and family support.

e) Refugee

A refugee is someone who has crossed an international border and is unable or unwilling to return home because they have a well-founded fear of persecution, or who otherwise meets the legal definition under refugee law.

f) Humanitarian Access

Humanitarian access means that aid workers can safely reach people affected by conflict and provide essential assistance such as food, water, medicine, shelter and protection. Blocking this help can put children's lives at risk. Denial of humanitarian access is one of the six grave violations monitored by the United Nations.

f) Reintegration

Reintegration means helping children who have been associated with armed forces or armed groups return to civilian life. Support may include reuniting children with their families, helping them return to school, providing healthcare and counselling, and helping their communities welcome them back.

3. General Context

Armed conflict has affected children for generations, but the international community has gradually developed clearer rules and systems to protect them. The Convention on the Rights of the Child, adopted in 1989, recognises that children have rights to safety, health, education, and development, including during difficult situations. In 1999, the UN Security Council formally placed children and armed conflict on its agenda. This helped create a stronger international focus on the way that wars affect children and on the responsibility of governments and armed groups to protect them. In 2005, the UN established the Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism to collect and check information about serious harm to children in conflict.

Children are affected by conflict not only when they are directly caught in fighting, but also when the systems they depend on stop working. Attacks and damage can leave families without safe homes, electricity, clean water, food, or medical care. Schools may close for long periods, meaning children lose learning, stability, and contact with friends and trusted adults. Some children are forced to flee, either to another part of their own country or across a border. By the end of 2024, an estimated 48.8 million children had been displaced by conflict and violence around the world (UNICEF Data, n.d.).

Children may also be recruited or used by armed forces and armed groups. Sme are abducted or threatened, while others may be pressured by poverty, a lack of protection, or the belief that joining an armed group is the only way to survive or protect their family or community. Children can be made to fight or given other roles, such as carrying supplies, acting as messengers, or gathering information. Whatever their role, they are still children in need of protection. Returning to civilian life can also be difficult. Children may need medical care, education, counselling, and support to reunite with their families and be accepted by their communities (UNICEF, 2021).

The scale of the problem remains serious. The UN verified 38,558 grave violations against children, affecting 24,174 children, in 2025. These figures show only the cases the UN was able to verify, so the real number may be higher, especially where fighting prevents investigators from reaching communities. The categories explained in the Definitions section help the UN identify patterns, report on the parties responsible, and press for changes. However, monitoring alone cannot keep children safe. Progress also depends on whether parties to conflict follow international law, allow humanitarian help to reach people in need, investigate abuses, and take steps to prevent them from happening again.

The situation differs between conflicts and changes over time. In Israel and the Occupied Palestinian Territory, the UN’s 2026 report recorded a very high number of verified violations affecting children during 2025 (United Nations Secretary-General, 2026). In Ukraine, children continue to face displacement and disruption to everyday life. In February 2026, UNICEF reported that more than one-third of the country's children remained displaced, either inside

Ukraine or as refugees abroad (UNICEF, 2026). These examples show why protecting children requires both immediate action during fighting and long-term support for families and communities afterwards.

4. Key Parties Involved and Their Perspectives

a) United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC)

The Human Rights Council discusses human rights issues, adopts resolutions, and can establish investigations or other mechanisms within its mandate. It can encourage governments to respect children's rights and work with UN bodies and humanitarian organisations. However, it does not directly command national armies or deliver all humanitarian aid itself

b) UNICEF

UNICEF works to protect children's rights and support their needs. In conflict areas, it may support education, healthcare, clean water, child protection, family reunification, and mental health support. It also helps children who leave armed forces or armed groups return to civilian life.

c) Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict

This office raises awareness of grave violations, supports monitoring and reporting, and engages with parties to conflict to try to stop violations. It also supports Action Plans with parties listed in the Secretary-General's reports.

d) Governments

Governments are responsible for protecting children in their territory and following the international laws that apply to them. They can support schools and hospitals, allow humanitarian aid, investigate violations, and help children recover. However, government forces can also be responsible for violations. The UN’s 2026 report found that government forces were

responsible for the largest share of verified grave violations in 2025 for the first time since the mandate began.

e) Non-State Armed Groups

Non-state armed groups are organised armed groups that are not a country's official armed forces. Some have been responsible for recruiting children, abductions, and attacks affecting civilians. It can be difficult for the UN and aid organisations to engage with these groups, but dialogue and written commitments have sometimes helped secure promises to stop violations and release children.

f) Humanitarian Organizations and NGOs

Organizations such as the International Committee of the Red Cross, Save the Children and other humanitarian groups provide support to people affected by war. Their work can include emergency aid, healthcare, education, and protection. They need safe access to affected communities, and attacks on aid workers or restrictions on access can prevent children from receiving help.

g) Children and Young People

Children should not only be viewed as victims. They are also people with rights, experiences, and ideas that can help shape better policies. Children affected by conflict may have different needs depending on their age, disability, family situation, displacement, and experiences. Their safety and privacy must be protected when their views are collected or shared.

5. Questions to Consider

1. How can countries make sure that existing laws protecting children during war are followed?
2. What can the UN do when a government or armed group is responsible for violations against children?

3. How can the recruitment and use of children by armed forces and armed groups be prevented?
4. What steps can help protect schools and hospitals during armed conflict?
5. How can humanitarian aid reach children in areas where fighting is taking place, or access is blocked?
6. What support should children receive after leaving an armed force or armed group?
7. How can displaced and refugee children be protected from exploitation, trafficking, and recruitment?
8. How can children continue to access education during and after conflict?
9. How can the UN monitor violations when investigators cannot safely reach an area?

6. Suggested Research Resources

Delegates should begin with reliable sources before using news articles, social media, or other secondary sources.

a) United Nations Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict

The UN's Children and Armed Conflict website contains information about the six grave violations, monitoring mechanisms, Action Plans, country situations and annual reports.

UN Office of the Special Representative for Children and Armed Conflict

b) UNICEF

UNICEF provides research and reports on children affected by conflict, including education, displacement, recruitment, humanitarian assistance and child protection.

UNICEF – Children and Armed Conflict

c) Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR)

OHCHR provides information about international human rights law, the Human Rights Council and the Convention on the Rights of the Child.

OHCHR

d) Convention on the Rights of the Child

Delegates should read Articles 38 and 39 of the Convention, which specifically address children affected by armed conflict and their recovery and reintegration. UNICEF Global

Convention on the Rights of the Child – UNICEF

e) International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC)

The ICRC provides resources explaining international humanitarian law and the protection of civilians and children during armed conflict.

International Committee of the Red Cross

f) UN Digital Library

Delegates can use the UN Digital Library to find Security Council resolutions, General Assembly resolutions, Human Rights Council resolutions, and Secretary-General reports.

United Nations Digital Library

7. Conclusion

Children should never have to risk their lives, lose their families, or miss years of school because of war. Yet armed conflict continues to expose children to violence, displacement, recruitment, exploitation, and the loss of essential services.

International rules and the UN mechanism provide important ways to protect children, report violations, and encourage those responsible to change their actions. However, rules are only effective when they are followed, and children can access the help they need.

Delegates should think about both prevention and recovery. Prevention means reducing the risk of children being harmed, recruited, or separated from their families. Recovery means helping children return to school, receive healthcare and emotional support, reunite with their families where possible, and rebuild their lives.

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